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ARCHIVO ABIERTO

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WHAT YOU MUST NOT SEE

This cartographic work simulates the cautious selection of information that appears in the media every day: sometimes to convey a powerful message, sometimes to hide what is not convenient to show when it comes to one of the biggest struggles that Mexico has faced for many years: violence and insecurity. The map invites the user to explore its layers in any order they wish, in order to gain a more complete overview of this topic. To do so, simply overlay each acetate sheet on the base map, aligning the marks that indicate the layer number. This allows the territory to be read in different ways: interchangeable but complementary layers that together tell a profound story, one that has become part of the daily lives of thousands of Mexicans.
This is: What you must NOT see.

To understand a country as vast and complex as Mexico, it is necessary to observe each of the layers that make it up, individually and as a whole. Each layer represents multiple dimensions of the space: from natural landscapes such as forests, jungles, mountains, and water bodies, which compose some of the most beautiful landscapes in the world, to human aspects: bustling cities, extensive urban areas, and the land networks that connect the entire country.

The infrastructure and natural spaces are the means by which territories function, but it is also where events and networks take place that are strongly hidden but still feed the fear of going out to experience the space.

Mexico's geographical characteristics allow the existence of diverse ecosystems that shelter more than 108,000 plant and animal species. Its hydrography, climate, and mineral-rich soils, combined with its varied terrain, including mountains, volcanoes, and valleys, make up a diverse and strategic territory.

The terrain is used in many ways by those who live there or those who control it, as strategic points for drug trafficking or to commit atrocities such as the disappearance of people.

Political and territorial organization is structured around its state borders and the motorways that allow access, transit, and exchange between regions. These routes transport goods thatv sustain thousands of families.

Interconnecting cities allows for a more efficient flow of information, promotes tourism, boosts trade, and strengthens the economic fabric.

Beyond legitimate flows of people and goods, the country's extensive transport network has been used for criminal purposes. As escape routes, meeting points, scenes of armed conflict and pursuits, and one of the main channels for human and drug trafficking, where victims are later handed over to criminal groups to be exploited or simply killed.

The everyday spaces of a country with rich and diverse culture have become scattered cemeteries, holding secrets, silenced voices, and tears from those who can no longer see the light above ground.

Thousands of mothers cross rivers, mountains, and borders in search of loved ones who once left for school, for work, or in pursuit of a better life, and never returned.

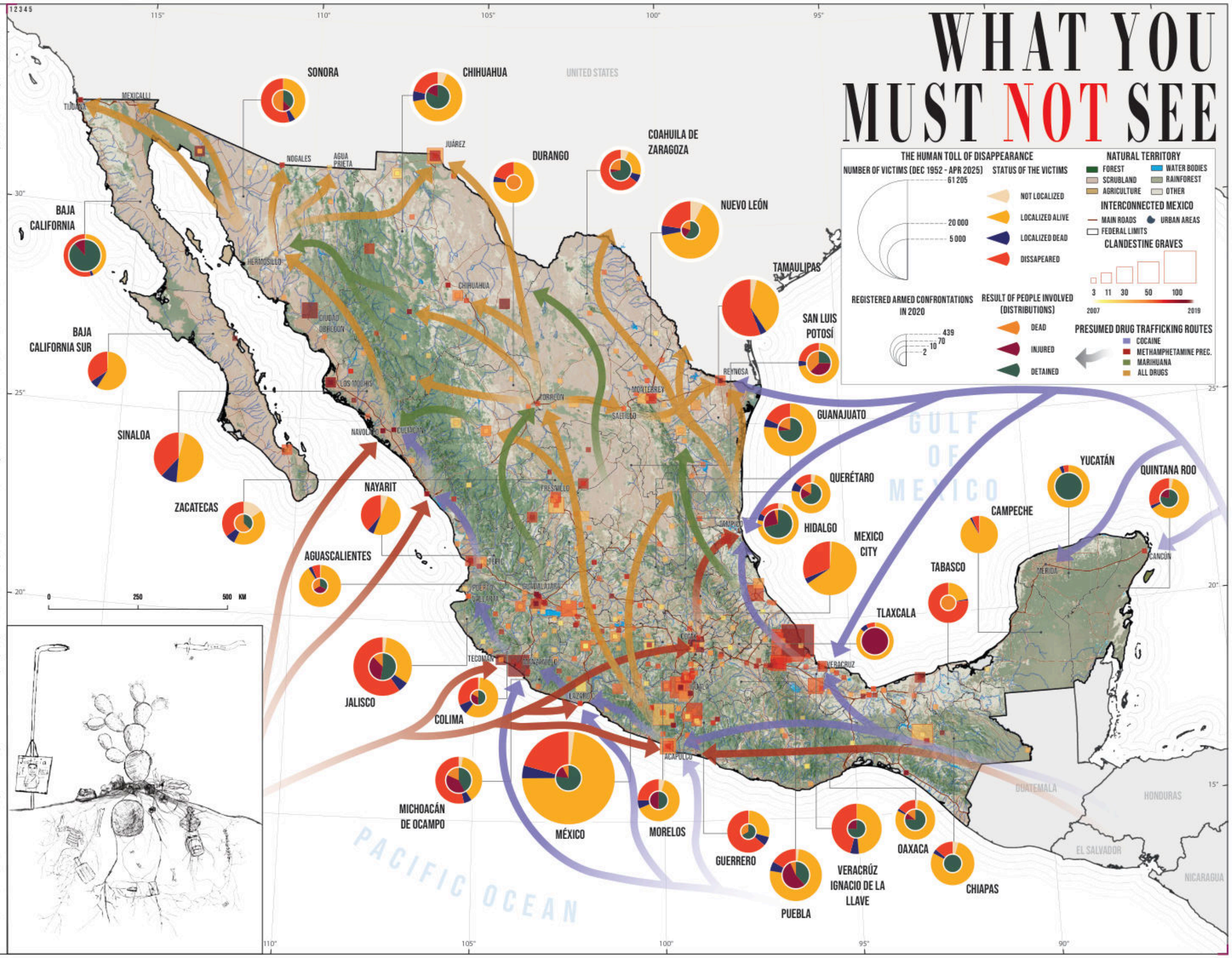
Mineral-rich land cultivates the food that fills our plates each day and sustains the power that drives the country forward.

On the other hand, beneath roads, grass, or trees lie thousands of buried identities, forgotten stories, and lingering sorrows that echo through murals pleading for truth.

It is no longer surprising to hear announcements about the discovery of a new clandestine grave, or that extermination centers and belongings belonging to those who were last seen before never returning home have been found on a piece of land.

The numbers paint a terrifying picture. After relentless searching, some people manage to return home; many others end up in a coordinate that barely helps to ease the anguish and put an end to the search, although with a broken heart.

These are not just lines on a map: they are trajectories based on structures of power, economic interests, and ambiguous legality. Each type of drug follows different paths, crossing specific regions and converging in others. Which reveals the territorial dominance of those who control the business and redefines the whole concept of "power".
It is no coincidence that these routes match up with the locations of disappearances. Violence has causes, trajectories, and intensities, and on this map, all of them become visible.



THE HUMAN TOLL OF DISAPPEARANCE

NUMBER OF VICTIMS (DEC 1952 - APR 2025)
61 205
20 000
5 000

STATUS OF THE VICTIMS
- NOT LOCALIZED
- LOCALIZED ALIVE
- LOCALIZED DEAD
- DISSAPEARED

REGISTERED ARMED CONFRONTATIONS IN 2020
439
70
10
2

RESULT OF PEOPLE INVOLVED (DISTRIBUTIONS)
- DEAD
- INJURED
- DETAINED

NATURAL TERRITORY

- FOREST
- SCRUBLAND
- AGRICULTURE
- WATER BODIES
- RAINFOREST
- OTHER

INTERCONNECTED MEXICO

- MAIN ROADS
- URBAN AREAS
- FEDERAL LIMITS

CLANDESTINE GRAVES

3 11 30 50 100
2007 2019

PRESUMED DRUG TRAFFICKING ROUTES

- COCAINE
- METHAMPHETAMINE PREC.
- MARIHUANA
- ALL DRUGS

CARTOGRAPHIC WORK MADE BY MIGUEL SOLANO FOR THE LECTURE MAP PROJECT CREATION. ERASMUS CARTOGRAPHY MSC.
BASED ON: INEGI (2020, 2021, 2025); RNPDNO (2025); CONABIO (1985, 1990); FAOBRO (2015); IBERO REPOSITORIO MX (2019); GADM (2025)